

CAMPUSCONNECT

Week 2 – User Research and Persona Development

A student-focused UX research report for a college digital portal redesign

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Project focus: making common college tasks easier to find, understand, and complete.

1. Week 2 Overview

Objective

Week 2 focused on understanding the students who may use CampusConnect, their common needs, frustrations and expectations. The goal was to turn this understanding into practical UX directions.

Research approach

This report uses secondary research from higher-education technology reports, accessibility standards and established UX guidance. The personas and empathy maps are synthetic design artifacts, not claims that these named people were interviewed.

Area	What was studied
Student experience	Technology expectations, flexibility, support and digital learning.
Usability	Navigation, visibility, consistency, error prevention and mental effort.
Accessibility	Keyboard access, focus, target size, readable content and predictable interaction.
Student tasks	Attendance, timetable, assignments, exams, results and announcements.
Competitive patterns	Common functions found in learning and student platforms.

Week 2 output

Four personas, four empathy maps, a user journey map, research findings, pain points, design opportunities and a validation plan.

2. Research Sources

The research used public sources that are relevant to higher-education technology and UX. They provide broad evidence and design guidance; they are not presented as a study of one specific college.

Source	Useful insight
EDUCAUSE – 2026 Students and Technology Report	Student technology needs are changing, with technology, course experience, workforce preparation and student support connected.
Jisc – 2024/25 HE Digital Experience Insights	Students generally value digital learning, while connectivity, device access, usability and support remain important issues.
W3C – WCAG 2.2	Accessibility should support different disabilities and devices; accessible design often improves usability for everyone.
Nielsen Norman Group – Usability Heuristics	Visibility, consistency, recognition, error prevention and simple design are useful UX checks.
Nielsen Norman Group – Empathy/Journey Mapping	These methods help teams understand attitudes, behaviour and the steps users take to complete a goal.

Research note: Jisc's 2024/25 HE survey included 15,398 respondents from 30 UK organisations. It reported 86% rating their digital learning environment above average, while 60% reported Wi-Fi issues and 37% lacked a suitable device at some point. These figures are directional evidence only.

3. Research Findings

Finding 1 – Students expect useful digital support.

A student portal should help people complete real tasks, not simply provide a collection of links.

Finding 2 – Digital experience still has practical barriers.

Connectivity and device problems make a responsive, lightweight and clear interface important.

Finding 3 – Important information needs strong visibility.

Students often open a portal for one reason: attendance, an assignment, an exam date or an announcement. High-frequency actions should be easy to find.

Finding 4 – Accessibility is normal UX.

WCAG 2.2 supports accessible experiences across devices. CampusConnect should not rely only on colour and should provide readable content, visible focus and usable controls.

Finding 5 – Good UX reduces remembering.

Labels, recent tasks, deadlines and clear navigation reduce the need for users to remember where information is hidden.

Finding 6 – Students have different priorities.

A first-year student may need guidance while a final-year student may care more about exams and results. The product needs a common structure that still supports different needs.

4. User Needs and Behaviour Patterns

Need	Why it matters	Design response
Fast access	Students may check the portal between classes.	Keep common actions visible.
Clear priorities	Not every notice has equal importance.	Use Today, Upcoming and Needs Attention.
Simple language	Institutional terms can confuse new students.	Use familiar labels.
Confidence	Users need to know whether an action worked.	Show clear confirmation and status.
Mobile-friendly	Quick checks often happen on phones.	Use responsive layouts and touch-friendly controls.
Accessibility	Different users need different interaction methods.	Follow WCAG principles.
Low mental effort	Repeated searching creates frustration.	Use predictable navigation and search.

Research-to-design principle: The portal should answer three questions quickly: **What needs my attention? Where do I find it? What should I do next?**

5. Persona 1 – Aanya Sharma

Type: Deadline-Focused Student **Age:** 20 **Stage:** Mid-program undergraduate

Background

Aanya manages classes, assignments and personal commitments. She usually checks college information from her phone and wants to finish small tasks quickly.

Goals

- See today's important tasks immediately.
- Know which assignment or deadline is closest.
- Check attendance without searching through several pages.
- Receive important notifications without overload.

Frustrations

- Information is spread across sections.
- Routine notifications hide important updates.
- Several pages may be needed for one detail.
- The portal does not show what needs attention first.

Quote

“Just tell me what needs my attention today.”

Needs from CampusConnect

Priority	Feature idea
High	Today / Needs Attention
High	Upcoming assignment and exam cards
Medium	Attendance snapshot
Medium	Notification priority
Low	Dashboard customization

Design implication: This persona supports a simpler, action-oriented and predictable portal experience.

6. Persona 2 – Rahul Verma

Type: New / Exploring Student **Age:** 18 **Stage:** First year

Background

Rahul is still learning how his college works. He understands normal digital apps but may not know the names used by the college for particular services.

Goals

- Find timetable, classes and assignments without asking others.
- Understand what each section is for.
- Know where to go when something goes wrong.
- Build confidence using the portal.

Frustrations

- Unfamiliar terms and abbreviations.
- Features are not always where expected.
- Errors may not explain what to do next.
- Too many choices can feel confusing.

Quote

“I know what I want to do, but I don't always know what the portal calls it.”

Needs from CampusConnect

Priority	Feature idea
High	Plain-language navigation
High	Search with common terms
Medium	Helpful error states
Medium	Simple onboarding tips
Low	Help centre / FAQ

Design implication: This persona supports a simpler, action-oriented and predictable portal experience.

7. Persona 3 – Arjun Rao

Type: Exam & Performance-Focused Student **Age:** 22 **Stage:** Final year

Background

Arjun mainly uses the portal for exams, results, attendance concerns, projects and official announcements. Accuracy and speed matter more than visual extras.

Goals

- Find exam dates, rooms and instructions quickly.
- Check results and academic status confidently.
- Avoid missing official announcements.
- See important academic deadlines together.

Frustrations

- Important information can mix with routine notices.
- Exam information may require several clicks.
- It may be unclear which notice is latest.
- Unclear status reduces trust.

Quote

“For exams, I need accurate information immediately.”

Needs from CampusConnect

Priority	Feature idea
High	Exam countdown and details
High	Pinned official announcements
High	Academic status summary
Medium	Calendar integration
Medium	Official detail download/share

Design implication: This persona supports a simpler, action-oriented and predictable portal experience.

8. Persona 4 – Meera Iyer

Type: Accessibility-Conscious Student **Age:** 21 **Stage:** Undergraduate

Background

Meera prefers interfaces that are predictable and easy to read. She notices when focus states, labels, contrast or touch targets are inconsistent.

Goals

- Navigate without depending on colour alone.
- Read information comfortably on different screens.
- Understand form errors and system status.
- Complete tasks with a keyboard when needed.

Frustrations

- Low contrast or small text.
- Small touch targets.
- Colour-only status indicators.
- Missing focus states.
- Inconsistent components.

Quote

“If the interface is predictable, I can focus on the task.”

Needs from CampusConnect

Priority	Feature idea
High	Keyboard-friendly navigation
High	Visible focus and clear labels
High	Accessible status indicators
Medium	Readable responsive layout
Medium	Text-size friendly components

Design implication: This persona supports a simpler, action-oriented and predictable portal experience.

9. Empathy Maps – Aanya & Rahul

Aanya

Says	Thinks
"I need to know what is due." "Where is my attendance?"	"Am I missing anything important?" "I don't have time to search."
Does	Feels
['Checks phone between classes; scans notifications; opens necessary pages.']	['Busy near deadlines; relieved when information is clear.']

Rahul

Says	Thinks
"Where can I find this?" "What does this option mean?"	"Am I using the right section?" "Maybe I should ask a friend."
Does	Feels
['Explores menus; searches terms; asks classmates when stuck.']	['Curious; uncertain with terminology; confident after guidance.']

Opportunity: Make the first screen understandable without training. Use task-based labels, short explanations and clear next steps.

10. Empathy Maps – Arjun & Meera

These maps are working hypotheses based on secondary research and persona needs. They should be validated later with real students.

Arjun

Says	Thinks
"Is this the latest notice?" "Where is my exam information?"	"I cannot afford to miss an update." "I need official information."
Does	Feels
['Checks announcements around exams; revisits results/status; verifies dates.']	['Focused; cautious; frustrated when information is buried.']

Meera

Says	Thinks
"I need a clear focus state." "Please don't use colour alone."	"Can I complete this without a mouse?" "Will this work on my device?"
Does	Feels
['Uses familiar patterns; adjusts text/zoom when needed; notices inconsistencies.']	['Comfortable with predictable interfaces; frustrated by barriers.']

Opportunity: Give important information strong hierarchy while keeping components accessible and consistent.

11. User Journey Map – Checking an Important Assignment

Scenario: A student opens CampusConnect on a phone to check whether an assignment is due today and what action is required.

Stage	Action	Thought / feeling	Pain point	Opportunity
1. Open	Logs in and reaches dashboard.	"I hope I can see it quickly."	Too many links slow the user.	Show Today and Needs Attention.
2. Scan	Looks at deadlines and alerts.	"Is this due today?"	Important items may look routine.	Use clear priority and date labels.
3. Select	Opens assignment details.	"What exactly do I submit?"	Details can be spread out.	Keep key details together.
4. Act	Views instructions or submission action.	"I know what to do."	Unclear CTA/status can cause mistakes.	Use one clear primary action.
5. Confirm	Checks status after acting.	"Did it work?"	Weak feedback creates doubt.	Show confirmation and status.

Journey insight: The best improvement is not only fewer screens; it is less uncertainty at every stage.

12. Key Pain Points

Pain point	Who	Priority	Why it matters
Information is scattered	All	High	Students spend time searching and may miss details.
Notification overload	Aanya, Arjun	High	Urgent information can disappear among routine updates.
Unfamiliar terminology	Rahul	Medium	Users may know the goal but not the portal label.
Hidden status	Aanya, Arjun	High	Attendance, submissions and results need clear status.
Accessibility barriers	Meera and others	High	Poor focus, small targets or colour-only status can block tasks.
Too many choices	Rahul, Aanya	Medium	Extra decisions increase mental effort.
Weak error feedback	Rahul, Meera	Medium	Users may not know how to recover.
Mobile friction	All	High	Quick student tasks often happen on phones.

Priority rule: Problems that could cause a missed deadline, exam update, attendance warning or submission should receive the highest design priority.

13. Design Opportunities

Opportunity	Problem	Possible solution
Action-first dashboard	Scattered information	Today, Upcoming and Needs Attention cards.
Priority notifications	Notification overload	Separate urgent academic notices from routine updates.
Quick status	Hidden status	Attendance, assignment and exam status snapshots.
Plain-language navigation	Terminology confusion	Labels such as Assignments, Exams, Attendance and Results.
Smart search	Finding sections	Search common student words and show direct results.
Accessible components	Accessibility barriers	Keyboard support, focus, readable text and non-colour status.
Responsive layout	Mobile friction	Design mobile-first and scale to desktop.
Clear confirmation	Uncertain actions	Success messages, timestamps and current status.
Contextual help	Errors/confusion	Guidance at the point of need.

Design direction: CampusConnect should feel less like a database of college information and more like a personal student task assistant.

14. Suggested Information Architecture

Area	Key content	Reason
Home	Today, Needs Attention, Upcoming, quick actions	Answers immediate questions.
Academics	Subjects, timetable, assignments, attendance	Groups learning tasks.
Exams	Schedule, room, instructions, countdown	High-impact information is easy to reach.
Results	Marks, academic status, history	Supports performance needs.
Announcements	Priority notices, college updates	Separates official communication.
Calendar	Classes, deadlines, exams	Time-based view.
Profile / Settings	Account, preferences, accessibility	Keeps personal settings clear.
Help	FAQs, support, issue reporting	Supports recovery.

Navigation principle: Keep primary choices small. Use clear page titles and show the user's current location.

15. Research Validation Plan

Method	Participants	Task / question	Output
Short interviews	5–8 students	How do you check attendance, assignments and exams?	Quotes, behaviours, recurring needs.
Task observation	5 students	Find an assignment; check attendance; find an exam date.	Navigation problems.
Quick survey	20–50 students	Rank portal problems and most-used features.	Priority trends.
Usability test	5–8 students	Test wireframes for common tasks.	Success, confusion and feedback.
Accessibility check	Representative users + manual checks	Keyboard, focus, contrast, text and target size.	Accessibility fixes.

Later success measures: Students find important tasks quickly; locate attendance/exams without help; understand notifications/status; complete common tasks on mobile; accessibility problems are found before final delivery.

16. UX Design Principles for CampusConnect

Principle	Application
Keep it simple	Show useful information first and avoid unnecessary decoration.
Make status visible	Show attendance, submission, exam and notification status clearly.
Use familiar language	Prefer student-friendly labels over internal terms.
Design for recognition	Use visible labels and predictable navigation.
Prevent errors	Use clear forms and helpful validation.
Give control	Allow appropriate notification/dashboard preferences.
Be consistent	Use the same buttons, cards and patterns throughout.
Design accessibly	Follow WCAG 2.2 and check keyboard, focus, target size and readable content.
Design for mobile	Assume many quick checks happen on small screens.
Reduce uncertainty	Tell the user what happened and what comes next.

Reference basis: These principles combine the research findings with Nielsen Norman Group usability guidance and W3C accessibility guidance.

17. Conclusion

Week 2 helped turn the general idea of CampusConnect into a clearer user-centered direction. Students need more than a place to store academic information. They need a portal that helps them understand what is important, find information quickly and feel confident after completing a task.

The four personas represent different priorities: Aanya needs speed and deadline visibility, Rahul needs guidance and simple language, Arjun needs accurate high-priority academic information, and Meera needs predictable and accessible interaction.

The main opportunity is to make CampusConnect action-oriented. The dashboard should surface what needs attention, while navigation, search, notifications, status messages and accessibility features reduce the effort needed to complete common tasks.

The next stage should validate these assumptions with real students through interviews, task observation and usability testing. Those results can then guide the information architecture, wireframes and final UI.

Week 2 outcome: a clear research foundation for moving from understanding users to designing solutions.

18. Research References

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Research integrity note: No invented interviews or fake survey results are presented as primary research. Personas and maps are synthetic UX artifacts based on secondary research and project assumptions.

19. Appendix – Week 2 Deliverable Checklist

Requirement	Included
User research findings	Yes
3–4 personas	Yes – 4 personas
Persona background/goals/frustrations/solutions	Yes
Empathy maps	Yes – 4 maps
User journey map	Yes
Pain points	Yes
Design opportunities	Yes
Research sources	Yes
UX/accessibility considerations	Yes
Validation plan	Yes
Next-stage design direction	Yes

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Week: 2 – User Research and Persona Development

End of Week 2 Report